Budgeting: Facilitator Guide

Business Academy Group Learning · Budgeting · December 2026

Session at a glance

In 60 minutes, providers refresh their Business Academy Budgeting Tool, learn their break-even point, and commit to updating their budget every month. As the first session of Year 2, it also welcomes new providers and sets the tone for the year.

Item	Detail
Month	December 2026
Audience	Business Academy providers, center-based and home-based
Length	60 minutes
Format	[In person / virtual]
Materials	Laptop and projector with a sample Budgeting Tool, name tags, sticky notes, calculators, printed Tips and Tricks sheet and Provider Handout
Ask providers to bring	A laptop or tablet with their Budgeting Tool, plus last month’s income and expense totals if they have them

Learning goals

By the end, each provider can:

1. Explain the difference between fixed and variable costs and why it matters.
2. Find their cost per child and break-even enrollment using the Budgeting Tool.
3. Run one “what if” scenario, such as a tuition change or an empty slot.
4. Commit to updating their budget monthly and reviewing it in coaching.

Agenda

Time	Segment
0:00 – 0:05	Welcome and opener: Year 2 kickoff and “One number I wish I knew”
0:05 – 0:15	Why a budget matters, and Year 1 results
0:15 – 0:30	Budgeting Tool walkthrough: costs, break-even, and scenarios
0:30 – 0:45	Activity: Run your own scenario
0:45 – 0:55	Implementation: your 30-day plan and one commitment
0:55 – 1:00	Takeaways and wrap-up

Why budgeting matters

Opener, “One number I wish I knew”: Welcome everyone, cover the year’s calendar, and have returning providers pair with new providers. Ask each person to share one number about their business they wish they knew for sure (for example, “what it really costs me per child”).

Talking points:

- **A budget is a plan, not a judgment.** It shows where money is expected to come from and go, so decisions are made on purpose instead of by surprise.
- **Year 1 proved it works.** In the FY26 pilot, the number of providers who felt confident creating a budget grew from 8 of 18 to all 18.
- **Year 2 is about using it.** The goal this year is to turn the budget into a monthly habit that guides real decisions about pay, tuition, and growth.
- **The budget answers big questions.** Can I give a raise? Can I afford to add a classroom? What happens if I lose two families? The Budgeting Tool can show the answer before you take the risk.
- **Small programs need it most.** With a few families, one empty slot can be the difference between breaking even and losing money.

Core content: key budgeting ideas

Walk through each idea in the Budgeting Tool using a sample program, then let providers find their own numbers.

Idea	What it means	Where to find it in the tool
Fixed costs	Costs that stay the same no matter how many children enroll: rent or mortgage, insurance, loan payments, base salaries.	Expense section
Variable costs	Costs that rise and fall with enrollment: food, classroom supplies, some staffing.	Expense section
Cost per child	Total annual costs divided by the number of children served. Compare this to what you charge.	Summary or per-child view
Break-even enrollment	The number of enrolled children needed for income to cover all costs.	Scenario or enrollment inputs
Vacancy and collections	Few programs are full and paid 100% of the time. Budget for realistic enrollment and some unpaid tuition.	Enrollment and revenue inputs
Scenarios	Change one input (tuition, a raise, a new hire) to see the effect before deciding.	Scenario tab or a copy of the budget
Reserve	Money set aside for emergencies. Many advisors suggest working toward about 3 months of expenses.	Savings line, if used

Exact labels may differ in the current version of the Budgeting Tool; check the updated VECF guidance before the session.

Implementation: your 30-day plan

Each provider leaves with one commitment and a 4-week plan; the Business Specialist checks progress at the next coaching session. Progress here also counts toward the pilot goal of at least one new or improved business practice per provider.

Week	Action	Done when
Week 1	Open the Budgeting Tool and update any fixed costs that changed this year (rent, insurance, wages).	Fixed costs are current
Week 2	Enter real enrollment and tuition, including vacancies and families who pay late.	Income reflects reality
Week 3	Find your cost per child and break-even enrollment; write both numbers down.	You know your two key numbers
Week 4	Enter last month's actual income and expenses and compare them to the budget.	First budget-to-actual comparison done

Tie-in to coaching

At the next individual coaching session, the Business Specialist will:

- ☐ Review the provider's updated fixed costs and enrollment
- ☐ Talk through cost per child and break-even enrollment
- ☐ Compare last month's actuals to the budget and discuss any gaps
- ☐ Note any business practice change in the provider's progress record

Commitment card

Have providers fill this in before they leave and keep a copy:

- My cost per child is: _____
- My break-even enrollment is: _____
- The scenario I want to test: _____
- I'll update my Budgeting Tool every month on: _____

Key takeaways

Close the session by reading these aloud; they also appear on the Provider Handout.

1. **Know your two numbers.** Cost per child and break-even enrollment drive every big decision.
2. **Budget for real life.** Plan for some empty slots and late payments, not a perfect year.
3. **Test before you decide.** Run a scenario before changing tuition, pay, or staffing.
4. **Update it monthly.** A budget only helps if it reflects what is actually happening.
5. **Build a cushion.** Even a small reserve protects your program from surprises.

Activities and discussion

Activity: Run your own scenario (15 minutes)

Each provider picks one question, such as “What if I raise tuition $10 a week?”, “What if I lose one child?”, or “What if I give my assistant a $1/hour raise?”, and tests it in a copy of their Budgeting Tool. Pairs share what changed. Debrief: Did anything surprise you?

Discussion questions

- What decision this year would be easier if you trusted your budget?
- What is the hardest cost for you to predict?
- How did you set your current tuition rates?
- What would you do with an extra $500 a month?

Peer Connections prompt (December)

“Introductions: who we are and what we want from this year.” Each provider shares their program, how long they’ve been open, and one business goal for the year. Returning providers share one thing the Budgeting Tool taught them in Year 1.

Handouts for this session

Walk through the **Budgeting Tips and Tricks** sheet during the content segment, and give out the **Budgeting Provider Handout** at the end.